

Cambodia is Drawn into the War

The Johnson administration had attempted to manage Cambodia's precarious neutrality, but the Nixon government launched several major operations within this small country that dragged it further into the wider war.

◀◀ BEFORE

From May 1965 to July 1969, there were no formal diplomatic relations between Cambodia and the United States.

TROUBLED RELATIONS

Against the backdrop of **historic border disputes** and ethnic tensions between the Cambodians and their Vietnamese neighbors, the rapidly **intensifying war** in Vietnam made it increasingly difficult for Cambodia to maintain its neutrality.

US INCURSIONS

Repeated **cross-border raids** against Viet Cong hideouts by ARVN forces, backed up by US advisers and air support, **brought tensions to a head**. Following an incident that left 17 Cambodian villagers dead, Norodom Sihanouk ordered US diplomats out of Phnom Penh.

President Johnson had placed some restrictions on US military and intelligence actions along the Cambodian border and had rejected a request from General Westmoreland for B-52 strikes along the frontier. Nevertheless, US reconnaissance and land-mining patrols, codenamed Salem House and later Daniel Boone, repeatedly entered Cambodia, and Cambodian villagers continued to suffer from ARVN raids planned with the US command.

Relations restored

Norodom Sihanouk did not like the Vietnamese communists' use of his country for their operations, but he wanted the United States to recognize Cambodia's borders, stop the incursions, and sever the ties that he perceived the Americans to have with his domestic rivals.

As a presidential candidate, Nixon had criticized Sihanouk as not truly neutral and agreed with military strategists who wanted more US operations in Cambodia. Once in office, however, he surprised almost everyone, including the leaders of South Vietnam, by recognizing Sihanouk's demands for respect for his country's rights and territory, and in July 1969 diplomatic relations were restored between the two countries. Nixon and Kissinger created a public image of cooperation with Sihanouk but the reopening of the US Embassy in Phnom Penh was also useful for intelligence gathering, a factor that was of growing importance as these diplomatic moves occurred in the wake of significant military developments.

“A ... **change of policy** toward Cambodia ... should be one of the [priorities] when we get in.”

RICHARD NIXON, NOTE TO HENRY KISSINGER, JANUARY 8, 1969